

THE EAGLE

Aquila



SIZE RANKING 22

BRIGHTEST STAR

Altair (α) 0.8

GENITIVE Aquilae

ABBREVIATION Aql

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
July–AugustFULLY VISIBLE
78°N–71°S

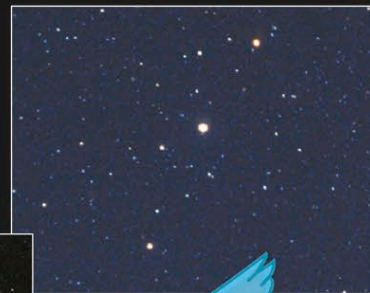
Aquila depicts an eagle in flight (see panel, right). It lies on the celestial equator in a rich area of the Milky Way near Cygnus, Scutum, and Sagittarius, yet there are no deep-sky objects of particular note within it. Aquila's brightest star, Altair or Alpha (α) Aquilae (see p.252), forms one corner of the northern Summer Triangle of stars, completed by Vega (in Lyra) and Deneb (in Cygnus).

Altair is flanked by 4th-magnitude Alshain, or Beta (β) Aquilae, and 3rd-magnitude Tarazed, or Gamma (γ) Aquilae, which form a distinctive trio.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Aquila's main feature of interest is Eta (η) Aquilae (see p.286), which is one of the brightest Cepheid variables. Eta ranges between magnitudes 3.5 and 4.4 on a cycle of 7.2 days. As with all members of this class, it is a brilliant supergiant. Its distance is estimated at 1,400 light-years.

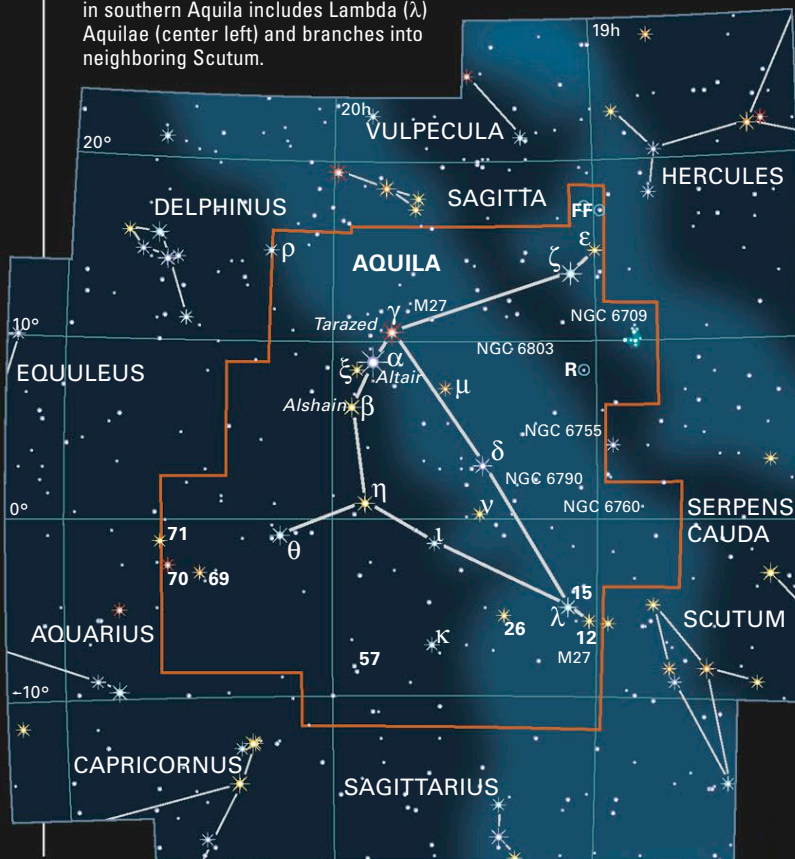
The constellation also has some faint double stars that can readily be split with a small telescope: 15 Aquilae, with stars of 5th and 7th magnitudes, and 57 Aquilae, with two 6th-magnitude components.



THE EAGLE

THE HOOK

This easily recognizable group of stars in southern Aquila includes Lambda (λ) Aquilae (center left) and branches into neighboring Scutum.



MYTHS AND STORIES

WINGED CARRIERS

The eagle has at least two identifications in Greek mythology. It was the bird that carried the thunderbolts for the god Zeus, and in one myth Zeus sent an eagle, or took the form of an eagle, to carry the shepherd boy Ganymede up to Mount Olympus, where he was made a servant of the gods. Zeus had spied the boy tending sheep in a field and had become infatuated with him. Ganymede is represented by neighboring Aquarius.



ON EAGLE'S WINGS

The beautiful youth Ganymede is carried aloft by an eagle in Peter Paul Rubens's 17th-century painting *The Abduction of Ganymede*.

STELLAR TRIO

Altair, the constellation's brightest star, is flanked by 3rd-magnitude Tarazed (top), which has a noticeably orange color, and 4th-magnitude Alshain (bottom), forming an attractive stellar trio.

SWOOPING ACROSS THE SKIES

The eagle swoops across the evening skies in the second half of the year. Its main star, Altair, is the most southerly of those that form the northern Summer Triangle. Aquila points toward the stars of Capricornus.